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Notable Jews petition against education bill in California - "Anyone who understands the threats that are currently facing the Jewish community can understand why AB 101, as well-intentioned as it may be, will unleash a torrent of anti-Jewish sentiment.

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Members of the Jewish Caucus in California have supported a controversial bill requiring ethnic studies for high school graduation, despite the fact it will enable the original Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum (ESMC) into California classrooms.

Roughly 70 rabbis, more than 1,000 California residents, and 75 religious and civil rights organizations petitioned against the AB 101 bill, which they believe to be highly antisemitic.

The petitioners pointed out that rising anti-Zionist-motivated antisemitism raise the stakes even further, as well as California school districts committing to adopting the original draft that many deem to be antisemitic.

They also noted that the two largest teachers unions in the state and several departments in the university that are responsible for training teachers, have endorsed BDS in the past, which is a cause of concern.

We were "deeply disappointed that not only did every Legislative Jewish Caucus Assembly member vote in favor of AB 101, but Caucus Chair Jesse Gabriel even made a speech on the Assembly floor that spoke about the bill in glowing terms and belittled concerns about antisemitism that were shared by a non-Jewish Assembly member," wrote the petitioners.

"Anyone who understands the threats that are currently facing the Jewish community can understand why AB 101, as well-intentioned as it may be, will unleash a torrent of anti-Jewish and anti-Zionist sentiment, hostility and aggression into classrooms throughout the state if it becomes law. The vast majority of California Jews understand this. As the CA Senate stands poised to vote on AB 101, please stand up and oppose this bill. There is still time to do the right thing," urged the petitioners.

The curriculum was written by The Liberated Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum Institute (LESMCI), which is a for-profit organization. It referred to Israel as an apartheid state and claimed it violates international law. They called the BDS movement a "global social movement that currently aims to establish freedom for Palestinians."

Additionally, the word antisemitism is not mentioned once in their 19-page curriculum glossary. However, it defines terms such as homophobia, Islamophobia, xenophobia, anti-Blackness, anti-Indigeneity and transphobia.

Ben Baruch contributed to this report.

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